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WE FAIL FROM OUR IGNORANCE

In early February 1840, as the Edens were heading down from Simla on their way back to Calcutta, they bumped into an old acquaintance from Scotland, Major-General William Elphinstone. The two families were friends, and the amiable, ineffective, bumbling old Major-General – an elderly cousin of Mountstuart Elphinstone – had last seen the Edens on his Carstairs estate in the Scottish Borders. Now, as he manoeuvred himself out of his palanquin, Elphinstone was rather put out to have to wait to see his young friend Auckland. 'It seems odd that I have never seen [Lord] A since we were shooting grouse together,' he told Emily, 'and now I have to ask for an audience and for employment.'[1]

The feeling of disappointment was mutual. If Elphinstone was mildly ruffled by their relative change of status, the Edens were worried by the mere sight of Elphinstone. Since their days striding over the border heather, guns under their arms on the Glorious Twelfth, Elphinstone's health had collapsed and he was now 'in a shocking state of gout, poor man! One arm in a sling and very lame', unable to walk unless supported, or aided by sticks. In fact it was so bad that at first Emily didn't recognise him: 'I remember him as "Elphy Bey", and never made out it was the same man till a sudden recollection came over me a week ago.'[2] It was, she wrote, 'almost the worst [case of gout] I ever saw'.[3]